

Figure 2.17 *The "lost"* minar *of Qala'-yi Zarmurgh, c. 75 km south of Jam-Firuzkuh. From Thomas 2014: 26.*

2.17–2.19) in material as well as form: the latter's decorative bands were fashioned with baked brick and some stucco so that, where brick was used, the decorative repertory was limited to geometric and minimally curving designs.[52] By contrast, the exclusive use of a malleable plaster on Ghur's central–southern remains accommodated curving and semi-floral patterns, even in deep relief. While the Da Qadi *minar* emulated the baked-brick Saljuq and Ghaznavid towers – aspiring to a "cosmopolitan" building tradition prevalent throughout the Persianate regions, as discussed below – central–southern Ghur's *qasr*, *qala'* and *kushk* emerged from a distinct architectural culture. Despite Juzjani's general attribution of the ruins to the tenth or early eleventh century, and modern scholars' general acceptance of the date, many of central–southern Ghur's ruins point toward an *earlier* span of time, namely the late or post-Sasanian–early Islamic periods of the late seventh–tenth centuries. (It is impossible to ascribe this timeframe to *all* of Ghur's remains, given the current inaccessibility of the region for first-hand documentation.)

The pre-Islamic affinities and chronology of the construction and decoration of many of central–southern Ghur's structures are borne out by juxtaposition with stucco architectural decoration dating to the later Sasanian centuries (Figures 2.21, 2.22, 2.24). Several sites in the vast empire's easternmost reaches – notably excluding western Afghanistan[53] – have undergone archaeological exploration/excavation and analyses of their stucco decoration, *viz.* Bandian (fifth century CE), Tepe Hissar near Damghan (fifth–sixth century), and Mele Hairam near Sarakhs (fifth–seventh centuries) (all in modern Iran). However, given the fragility of stucco as a material, and the consequent loss of much of the original Sasanian corpus, relevant examples from different periods and regions of Sasanian ascendancy must also be considered.[54]

Repetitive and abundant molded patterns suffused many of the plaster surfaces of central–southern Ghur's built remains (Figures 2.13–2.16, 2.20), demonstrating a palpable resonance with Sasanian parallels. The curved and